

I was born with Friedreich's Ataxia, a super rare neuromuscular disease that affects coordination, balance, and movement. I was diagnosed in 2013 when I was only nine years old. Growing up with it was difficult because most people had never heard of the disease, and they often misunderstood my symptoms.

In 2018, I was in Grade 9. At that point, I was still able to walk, but I was extremely uncoordinated and clumsy. I fell constantly, stumbled when I walked, and struggled to keep my balance. Because of the way I moved, people often assumed I was drunk or high. Some people even gave me the nickname "Captain Jack Sparrow" because of the way I walked.

That summer, I was at the Carp Fair with a group of friends. We were hanging around near the vendor booths, joking around and talking, when a man suddenly approached me. Without asking, he put his hand on my shoulder and started staring into my eyes. Then he turned to his partner and said, "I think we need an ambulance."

I immediately pushed his hand away and told him not to touch me. I was completely shocked and honestly didn't know how to react. I tried explaining that I had a rare disease, but instead of listening, he laughed arrogantly like he didn't believe me. At that point I laughed back and told him he was going to get himself into trouble.

Luckily, one of my friend's moms worked in the fair's head office. We went to find her and explained what had happened. She was absolutely furious and confronted the man immediately. The second she started questioning him, all of his smugness and arrogance disappeared. That moment stuck with me because it showed how quickly people judge others without knowing anything about what they are actually going through.